

World in Brief: Ships halt in the Strait of Hormuz; death toll in Venezuela rises



Photograph: Getty Images

Shipping was halted in the **Strait of Hormuz** after [Iran attacked](#) a Singapore-flagged cargo ship. Earlier Iran warned ships only to use routes that it had approved. The incident prompted the UN's International Maritime Organisation to pause its plans to evacuate sailors stranded in the strait. Oil prices also jumped in response.

The confirmed death toll from Wednesday's [earthquakes](#) in Venezuela reached 589, with nearly 3,000 injured. The two quakes were the country's largest—and possibly deadliest—in over a century. Countries around the world pledged support. America sent two navy ships and transport planes. The IMF committed \$200m to rebuild infrastructure, according to Delcy Rodríguez, Venezuela's acting president.

America's trade deficit in **goods** was nearly \$106bn in May, a 27% increase from April and the widest gap in more than a year. Imports rose by around \$11bn as firms stocked up on capital goods, a category which includes computing equipment, amid expectations of price rises caused by supply constraints. Meanwhile, exports dropped by nearly \$12bn, as overseas demand for consumer goods and industrial products weakened.

A tech-stock sell-off dragged **Asian markets** down. Reports that OpenAI might delay [its IPO](#) sent shares in SoftBank—one of Japan's largest companies, which owns a sizeable stake in the AI lab—lower, pulling down the Nikkei 225 by more than 4%. South Korea's KOSPI dropped by nearly 6%, led by falls in Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix, two makers of memory chips central to the AI boom.

Volkswagen aims to cut up to 100,000 jobs—double what had been previously suggested—according to reports in a German business magazine, which the carmaker has not confirmed. vw is downsizing following a fall in sales over recent years. Intense competition from China and Donald Trump's tariffs on imports into America have squeezed demand. It also reportedly plans to shut factories; labour unions have vowed to fight it.

The **Trump administration** asked **OpenAI** to restrict the release of its latest model to government-approved partners before fully rolling it out. The firm is now expected to give access to GPT 5.6 to a handful of companies vetted by American officials. The request is another attempt by America to become the [gatekeeper for frontier AI models](#).

Kim Keon Hee, a former first-lady of **South Korea**, was sentenced to seven years in jail for receiving bribes. Ms Kim was found to have offered jobs and favours in return for luxury goods, including jewellery from Tiffany and a Dior handbag. She is married to [Yoon Suk Yeol](#), who was ousted as president (and subsequently jailed for insurrection) after declaring martial law in 2024.

Figure of the day: 143, the number of Chinese EV brands that sold at least one model last year. Read about the country's [strange and crowded industry](#).

US in Brief: The nine and the one



Photograph: Getty Images

The **Supreme Court** bolstered Donald Trump’s **immigration** crackdown. In 6-3 decisions along ideological lines, it found that migrants could not claim asylum if not in the country, meaning they can be turned back at the border. It also ruled that the administration could scrap protections of Haitians’ and Syrians’ rights to work and live in America. Some 350,000 Haitians and 6,000 Syrians could therefore be deported. The White House called it a “tremendous win”. But its streak could end when the court rules on birthright citizenship, a high-profile immigration case [The Economist’s forecasting model](#) expects the administration to lose. Eight cases are yet to be decided this term.

In another 6-3 decision, [the Supreme Court](#) struck down a Hawaiian law that bars permit holders from carrying **guns** on private premises without express permission from the property owner. It is the latest gun-control law to be toppled in accordance with the court’s landmark decision in 2022 to require gun laws to align with the country’s “history and tradition”. On Thursday justices also blocked lawsuits over firms’ failure to warn consumers about potential health hazards. A cancer patient had sued Monsanto, a firm owned by **Bayer**, arguing that its Roundup weedkiller should warn of carcinogenic risk.

The Trump administration is sending a multi-agency task force to **Venezuela** to help the country recover from a pair of devastating earthquakes. At least 235 people were killed and thousands injured. The State Department, which is co-ordinating efforts with support from the War Department, said it would provide an assistance programme worth \$150m. But critics argued that the Trump administration's [dismantling of USAID](#), the development agency that previously led most international-disaster responses, had complicated relief efforts.

Leonie Brinkema, a federal judge, said that a lawsuit challenging the Department of Justice's \$1.8bn "**anti-weaponisation**" fund will go ahead. She noted that the DoJ had refused to sign a declaration confirming that [the fund](#) is dead. Todd Blanche, the acting attorney-general, claimed in recent testimony that it would not proceed; the DoJ's lawyers argued that was sufficient to dismiss suits challenging the fund.

Prosecutors in Manhattan dropped a rape charge against **Harvey Weinstein** after his accuser declined to testify in another trial. In 2024 New York's top court [overturned felony sex-crime charges](#) against the Hollywood mogul, deeming his 2020 trial unfair. He was convicted of sexual assault and acquitted of another charge after retrials, but juries were twice undecided on this final case. Mr Weinstein denies the allegations.

Ron DeSantis, Florida's governor, said that **Alligator Alcatraz**, an infamous immigration detention facility, is closed. Inmates have been relocated to other facilities. Some 21,000 people were deported after being held in the makeshift camp, which opened in July 2025 and housed over 900 immigrants in the kind of plastic tents used for big parties. It was not run by the federal government or experienced private contractors, but by Florida's emergency-management agency. Detainees and human-rights activists had warned of [appalling conditions](#).

Peace with Iran divides the Gulf

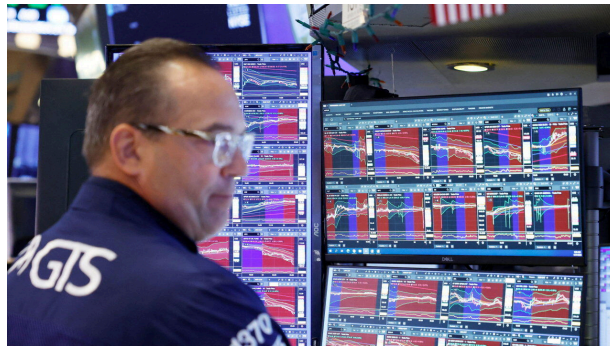


Photograph: Reuters

On Thursday Marco Rubio promised a group of Gulf foreign ministers that any [peace deal](#) struck between America and Iran would take them into account. America's secretary of state was speaking at the end of a three-day tour of Bahrain, Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates. His audience might well have been sceptical: Iran has attacked the Gulf with thousands of missiles and drones this year. And while [all six Gulf states](#) supported the ceasefire that was signed on June 17th, they doubt it will end the war for good—and disagree over what to do next.

Oman has tried to stay on friendly terms with Iran: this week it welcomed a high-level Iranian delegation. Saudi Arabia is more suspicious of the Islamic Republic, but open to diplomacy. (It hopes to organise reconciliation talks between Iran and Gulf countries soon.) The UAE sees Iran as an implacable foe; it prefers containment to conciliation. The Gulf is factious at the best of times. These are anything but.

A jittery week for tech stocks



Photograph: Alamy

Over the next six years businesses will spend \$7.6trn on AI infrastructure, estimates Goldman Sachs Global Institute, part of the investment bank. Two-thirds will go towards [compute](#), the processors that train and run AI models. Such spending has propelled chipmakers' share prices to record highs.

But concerns about higher [interest rates in America](#), and doubts about the sort of forecasts Goldman Sachs is making, are testing those valuations. The expected stock-market debuts of OpenAI and Anthropic are prompting investors to question their optimistic assumptions about the chipmakers' biggest customers. Since Monday an index of leading semiconductor companies has dropped by 6%.

Micron Technology, an American memory-chip maker, eased worries on Wednesday, when it reported that its quarterly revenue had more than quadrupled from a year earlier. Such results suggest that AI spending has not yet slowed. Still in question, though, is whether chipmakers' customers will make enough profit to continue the spree.

Turkey's opposition in disarray



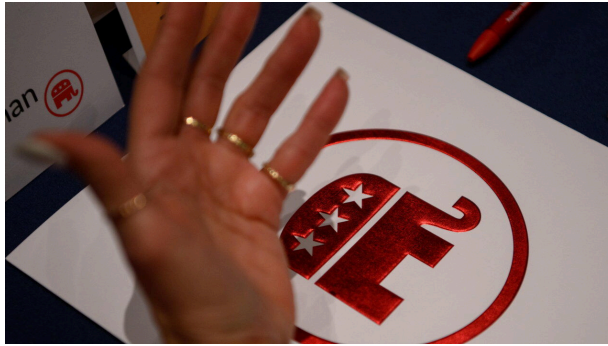
Photograph: Reuters

Last month a Turkish court ousted the Republican People's Party leader, Ozgur Ozel, and replaced him with Kemal Kilicdaroglu (pictured), the party's former chairman and loser of the 2023 presidential elections. It was the latest salvo in the war of attrition that Turkey's president, Recep Tayyip Erdogan, has been waging against [the country's democracy](#) and its main opposition group.

Mr Kilicdaroglu now faces open rebellion. Over 800 delegates are calling for an extraordinary congress to elect a new leader. Unless he takes action by Friday, the rebels will ask the courts to step in. But Mr Kilicdaroglu argues that preparations for a congress could only start in September. He has meanwhile begun a purge, ousting Mr Ozel's supporters from provincial leadership positions.

Mr Ozel faces a tough choice. Trying to wrest back control over the CHP risks a prolonged crisis. And there are major legal and financial hurdles to founding a rival party. Mr Erdogan has the CHP right where he wants it.

A financial GOPportunity



Photograph: Getty Images

On Friday conservative high-rollers will whip out their wallets at the Republican National Committee's finance retreat. The cheques they write will add to the RNC's cash advantage: as of May, the group had \$125m cash on hand, eight times more than the Democratic National Committee. Donald Trump's fundraising super-PAC is even richer, with nearly \$370m. Democratic donors are still skittish after the nightmare of 2024, when they spent more than \$6bn, only to lose both the White House and Congress.

But money may not be decisive in the midterm elections scheduled for November. Democratic voters, burning to punish the president, have been turning out in record numbers in several recent primaries and special elections. The party will probably win control of the House of Representatives, and perhaps the Senate, despite Republicans' cash advantage. The RNC will use the money it raises on Friday to fight [the midterms](#). But Mr Trump's PAC may wait to spend its cash on something else.

Europe suffers under sweltering heat



Photograph: Zeynep Demir Aslim/ZUMA Press/eyevine

Europeans have even more reason than usual to be thankful it's Friday. Western Europe has sweated through a [record-breaking heatwave](#) since last week: much of France and Spain endured over 40°C (104°F); Britain's Met Office issued its second-ever "red" warning, used when heat puts fit and healthy people at risk. Temperatures are forecast to drop this weekend.

But the damage will take longer to reveal itself. Hundreds of heat-related deaths in Spain have already been reported. In France over 48 people have drowned trying to cool off. Far more deaths will have actually occurred. During the 2022 European heatwave (the previous record holder), at least 60,000 people died across 35 countries. Scientists' best estimate is that climate change has made this week's weather 2-4°C hotter. With electricity grids straining under increased air-conditioning demand, schools closed and (in France) nuclear reactors shut down, the need for Europe to adapt faster is obvious.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which British-born officer is generally regarded as the “father of the American Navy” for his exploits in the Revolutionary war?

Thursday: Which American oil tycoon haggled with the kidnappers when his grandson was taken in 1973?

*Above all, be the heroine of your
life, not the victim.*

Nora Ephron